

how some brokers were able to consistently get orders from UTI by giving expensive gifts to the officials in the investments department.

Reliance Industries, ACC, Grasim, Bajaj Auto, Century Textiles, ITC, GE Shipping, Century Enka, Castrol, TELCO (Tata Electric Locomotive Company then, and Tata Motors now), TISCO (Tata Iron and Steel Company), Tata Tea and Tata Chemicals were among the most actively traded stocks of those days.

Nemish Shah, Manu Manek and Ajay Kayan were the high rollers, revered by market players for their ability to make or break a stock. Manu Manek was more feared than respected because he could be downright ruthless to further his business interests. It could be safely said that, as the biggest badla financier on the exchange floor, Manubhai was the final arbiter of the interest rate to be paid by the bulls for carrying forward their trades to the next settlement. He had no qualms about hammering down the price of the very stock he had financed for a bull operator. Manubhai, who was considered something of a mini-stock exchange himself, could quickly figure out a bull operator's capacity to support the stock he was operating. If the operator was weak, Manek would short-sell the stock. And once the operator made a distress sale, Manek would buy back the shares cheaper than he had sold them for, making a tidy profit in the process.

He had an uncanny ability to commit hundreds of trades to memory. While in the ring, he rarely noted down his trades in the *sauda pad* (deal sheet), even though he dealt in multiple stocks. At the end of the day, he would get back to his office and dictate the trades to his clerks.

And he had one more strong point – an excellent rapport with the key officials in the Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE) employees' union. Call it a coincidence, but whenever Manek was in a tight spot over a trade, there would be a flash strike by the employees' union, and the settlement would get extended by a few days, helping him buy time.

Manek was fearless enough – or reckless, as the subsequent turn of events would show – to take on Dhirubhai Ambani by leading a bear raid on the shares of Reliance Industries. The bear cartel heavily short-sold Reliance Industries, aiming to break the stock price. There are two versions of the story, and I am not sure which one is true. One has it that it was a planned operation by Manek to assert to Dhirubhai his hold on the stock market. The other has it that Reliance's treasury department (which deploys the funds of the company in various financial instruments to get the best